Finally the two met and had a long conversation about spirituality, presumably in Braj. For it was from the time of Akbar that Braj became the naturalized idiom of the Mughals. Akbar was completely conversant with spoken Hindi, in addition to Persian and Turki, as well as having a working knowledge of Arabic, and as for Salim, Braj was his mother tongue, and he would become a fine poet in the language. Even if Persian remained the official public language, in the intimacy of the harem and in their private lives, the Padshahs also spoke Braj with their Rajput wives and their Hindu courtiers.

As for Tansen, he continued to mesmerize the court for a quarter of a century, and the only courtier immune to the charm of his singing appears to have been Shaikh Mubarak. ‘He compared his singing to the noise of beasts,’ gloated Badauni, ‘and allowed it no superiority over it,’ an assessment which may have been influenced by the fact that Tansen by then was a very old man, his finest singing days long past.

Every evening before the entertainment began, there was the ceremonial lighting of lamps and candles at the end of the day, which was a sacred task. On the day when the sun entered the nineteenth degree of Aries, a lustrous white stone called the Surajkrant was held up to it, with a piece of cotton next to it. The reflected heat of the stone soon lit up the cotton, and this fire was kept burning for a year in a vessel called the Agnigir—all the candles, torches, and lamps of the palace were lit from this source. In the evening, which fell suddenly like a malediction, twelve white candles on gold and silver candlesticks would be brought to Akbar, and a ‘singer of sweet melodies, with a candle in his hand’ would sing a number of songs praising God while the Padshah stood in concentrated silence. Once all the lamps and candles were lit, the palaces and courtyards of Fatehpur Sikri would be ablaze with flickering light; some of the candlesticks and wax candles were so tall that a ladder was needed to snuff them out.

Every evening Akbar would also inspect the palace guards, who were comprised of an unusual tribe of men called the Chandals, described by Abu’l Fazl as ‘unequalled in India for wickedness’. Considered outcastes and highway robbers, Akbar had wanted to encourage them to change their ways and he gave them the title ‘Rai’ and their chief was called Khidmat Rai. Akbar ‘guided him towards honesty’ and following the Padshah’s example, all the noblemen had taken to employing these ‘Khidmatiya’ as guards. The mounting of the guards was an important duty and Akbar